

freebirth guide

Understanding Freebirth

- Freebirth means choosing to give birth without a midwife or doctor present
- You are the primary decision maker throughout labour and birth
- This choice comes with full responsibility and preparation of birth and all outcomes
- Feeling informed, supported, and grounded is key

Role of Your Doula

- Your doula is there to support you, but not replace medical care.

Your doula:

- Provides emotional, physical, and informational support
- Helps you stay calm, focused, and connected to your instincts
- Supports your environment (lighting, noise, privacy)
- Offers comfort (massage, grounding, reassurance)

Your doula does **NOT**:

- Perform medical tasks (no vaginal exams, no monitoring equipment)
- Diagnose or assess medical conditions
- Deliver your baby in a clinical sense
- Take responsibility for medical decisions

 They may:

- Encourage you to seek help if you feel that something isn't okay
- Call emergency services when you/your partner asks
- Freebirth is legal. However, it is a criminal offence for someone other than a registered midwife or doctor to attend childbirth, except in an emergency. Doulas can provide emotional/practical support, but they cannot act as the midwife.



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Freebirth Supplies

For you:

- Maternity pads
- Towels (LOTS)
- Water/fuel
- Comfortable clothing
- birth comb

For baby:

- Blankets/clothes
- Nappies
- Cord ties
- Clean scissors (if planning to cut cord)

Other:

- Bowl/container for placenta
- Bin bags
- Sick bucket
- Incontinence pads



Helpful Tools for Labour

- Birth ball
- Rebozo/scarf
- Essential oils
- Water (bath/shower/pool)
- Breathing techniques
- Affirmations or calming audio
- Movement and position changes



Safety & Transfer Planning (Very Important)

Even if you plan to freebirth, prepare for change:

- Know when to call 999
- Identify your nearest hospital and route
- Keep your phone fully charged
- Pack a small “just in case” bag



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Preparing Your Birth Space

Create an environment that supports oxytocin (the birth hormone):

- **Lighting & Atmosphere:** Dim the lights, use fairy lights or battery-operated tea lights to create a warm, cozy "cave" atmosphere.
- **Think about your place of birth,** have towels ready as well as think about a birth pool/bath for access to water.
- **Think about pain management techniques** like breathwork, hypnobirthing techniques, birth combs, counter pressure and use of biomechanics to help baby position.
- **Scent:** Bring familiar, calming scents using diffusers or linen sprays (like lavender) to make the space feel safe and familiar.
- **Sound:** Prepare playlists with relaxing music, calming birth affirmations, or calming nature sounds or your favourite music to enjoy.
- **Comfort & Items:** Use your own pillow, comfortable clothes, and blankets to make the environment cozy.
- **Visuals & Inspiration:** Display positive affirmation cards, photos of loved ones, or calming images.
- **Mobility & Support:** Ensure there is space for movement, such as using a birth ball, mat, or floor space.
- **Privacy:** Use "do not disturb" signs or keep doors/curtains closed to ensure privacy.
- **Your Team:** Surround yourself only with people who support your birth goals and help you feel safe.

There is a homebirth checklist on the Hub– please download it!



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During Labour

- Trust your body, it knows what to do
- Eat, drink, and rest when needed
- Follow your instincts with movement and position
- Keep your environment calm and protected
- Avoid unnecessary observation or pressure



Immediately After Birth

- Bring your baby straight to your chest (skin to skin)
- Keep you and your baby warm (towels/blanket)
- Allow undisturbed bonding (golden hour)
- Watch for baby's first feeding cues
- Delay cord cutting if that feels right



Placenta Stage

- Usually births within 30–60 minutes
- Stay relaxed and upright if possible
- Do not rush, let your body lead

Keep an eye on:

- Bleeding (steady trickle = normal, heavy flow = not)
- How you feel (alert, stable, aware)
- Write down:
 - Time of birth
 - Place of birth
 - Baby's sex



Emotional & Physical Recovery

- Rest as much as possible
- Eat nourishing food and stay hydrated
- Accept help from others
- Talk through your birth if needed



Remember: Transfer is not failure, it's responsive decision-making



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NHS Notification After a Freebirth (Important)

- If your baby is born without a midwife or doctor present, there is an additional NHS step to be aware of.



Within 36 hours (Recommended)

- If no healthcare professional has seen you or your baby within 6 hours of birth, NHS guidance advises:
- You should email the Child Health Information Service (CHIS) (contact your local area)
- This helps create your baby's NHS number and health record

More guidance here:

<https://www.england.nhs.uk/publication/birth-notification-process-for-unassisted-births/>



What to include:

- Your full name
- Baby's date and time of birth
- Address where baby was born
- Baby's sex
- Any relevant contact details



Important to understand:

- This is NHS guidance (recommended)



Birth Registration (Legal Requirement)

- Must be done within 42 days
- Done through your local registry office (e.g. in Birmingham)
- This is what:
- Legally records your baby's birth
- Triggers wider NHS system updates (including CHIS)

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Postnatal Care (Recommended)

- Contact services via the NHS:

You can:

- Call your GP
- Contact local midwifery team

Request:

- Newborn check (ideally within 72 hours)
- Postnatal check for yourself
- Feeding support if needed



Simple Timeline for post birth

Immediately after birth

- Skin-to-skin
- Rest and bond
- Ensure baby is breathing and feeding

Within 36 hours (recommended):

- Email CHIS (if no professional has attended)

Within a few days you should:

- Contact GP or midwife team
- Arrange newborn checks
- Within 42 days register the birth

Seek support if:

- You feel overwhelmed, low, or anxious
- You have ongoing physical concerns
- Feeding is difficult or painful



Call for help if:

- Heavy bleeding
- Baby is not breathing or has poor tone
- You feel faint, collapse, or lose consciousness
- Labour feels “wrong” or concerning